

Guidelines for CLPsych 2026 Shared Task

Capturing and Characterizing Mental Health Changes through Social Media Timeline Dynamics

Introduction:

CLPsych has brought together researchers in computational linguistics and NLP, who use computational methods to better understand human language, infer meaning and intention, and predict individuals' characteristics and potential behavior, with mental health practitioners and researchers, who are focused on psychopathology and neurological health and engage directly with the needs of providers and their patients.

Important Dates:

- ☐ **March 11:** Guidelines Released: Access to CLPsych 2026 shared task guidelines
- ☐ **March 11:** Training Data Released: Task 1 and Task 2 training data becomes available
- ☐ **March 24:** Test Set Released: Task 1 and Task 2 test sets shared with participants
- ☐ **March 24:** Baselines Available: Codabench baselines for Task 1 and Task 2 released
- ☐ **March 31:** Submission Deadline: Test set submissions due for Task 1 and Task 2 on Codabench
- ☐ **March 31:** Training Data Released: Task 3.1 and Task 3.2 training data released (including dev timeline information)
- ☐ **April 13:** Test Set Released: Task 3.1 and Task 3.2 test sets shared with participants
- ☐ **April 13:** Baselines Available: Codabench baselines for Task 3.1 and Task 3.2 released
- ☐ **April 19:** Submission Deadline: Test set submissions due for Task 3.1 and Task 3.2 on Codabench
- ☐ **April 20:** Results Announcement
- ☐ **April 21:** Regardless of paper submission, teams must send a **~75-word summary of their best system for each subtask** to igra.ali@gmul.ac.uk for inclusion in the overview paper.
- ☐ **May 1:** Participant System Papers Due
- ☐ **May 15:** Camera-Ready Papers Due

All deadlines are 11:59 PM AOE (Anywhere on Earth)
Any changes in the above timeline will be communicated to the team leads through email.

Please Note: The shared tasks follow a staged schedule. Training data and test sets for different tasks will be released at different times throughout the competition. This staged release allows participants to work on tasks sequentially and ensures that the development and evaluation phases are clearly separated for each task. Participants should follow the timeline carefully as new datasets and evaluation phases become available.

Task Overview

The CLPsych 2026 Shared Task builds on the longitudinal modeling paradigm introduced in CLPsych (2022, 2025), which focused on detecting changes in individuals' mental states and well-being, as reflected in social media timelines. The 2026 task further advances this line of work by integrating dynamic mental health modeling, emphasizing the identification of key self-state elements leading up to mental state changes over time. Participants will analyze temporally ordered sequences of social media posts to characterize detailed psychological processes, key changes, as well as the interplay of such self-state processes leading up to the changes. The task extends the CLPsych 2025 task which was grounded in the **MIND framework** (Atzil-Slonim, 2025) that conceptualizes self-states as combinations of **Affect, Behavior, Cognition, and Desire (ABCD)** components enabling the modeling of adaptive and maladaptive self-states over time. Specifically, this year's task aims to further explore the fine-grained elements contributing to changes. The core objective of the shared task is to develop computational models that can **identify adaptive and maladaptive self-state dimensions as well as changes over time across social media timelines aiming to characterize and summarize self-state sequences leading to such changes.**

Annotation Framework: The MIND Model

Self-states are conceptualized as structured combinations of the following components:

- **Affect (A):** Emotional tone or mood.
- **Behavior toward Self (B-S) and Behavior toward Others (B-O):** Actions or tendencies directed inward or outward.
- **Cognition toward Self (C-S) and Cognition toward Others (C-O):** Beliefs, interpretations, and appraisals.
- **Desire (D):** Motivations, needs, wishes, and expectations.

A **self-state** reflects a dominant mode of experiencing the self and others at a particular moment in time. At any given point, one self-state may be more dominant, shaping emotions, thoughts, motivations, and behaviors, while other self-states remain in the background and still exert subtler influence. Individuals differ in self-state flexibility—namely, their capacity to shift between self-states and sustain internal dialogue among them rather than becoming stuck in a rigid dominant state. Some self-states are more **adaptive** and support well-being, whereas others are more **maladaptive** and involve negative feedback loops, or self–other conflict. Self-states are dynamic: they fluctuate across time and context, and shifts in dominance and transitions between states may signal meaningful **change** in mental health. Modeling these transitions is central to the CLPsych 2026 task. Below is the ABCD Elements Table with Adaptive and Maladaptive Examples.

Participation Scope: Although teams are encouraged to tackle and submit solutions for all tasks in order to obtain a clearer overview of this year's challenge, participation in any subset of subtasks is allowed. Teams choosing to participate will also be invited to submit system description papers detailing their approaches and results.

Task Details

All post examples used in these guidelines have been paraphrased for privacy preservation purposes

Task 1: Predict adaptive and maladaptive ABCD element combinations

A self-state is defined as an identifiable unit characterized by specific combinations of Affect, Behavior (towards the self and others), Cognition (towards the self and others), and Desire (ABCD) that tend to be co-activated in a meaningful manner for limited periods of time. A self-state has either an adaptive or maladaptive valence. An **Adaptive self-state** pertains to aspects of Affect, Behavior (towards the self and others), Cognition (towards the self and others) that are conducive to the fulfillment of basic desires/needs. A **Maladaptive self-state** pertains to aspects of Affect, Behavior (towards the self and others), Cognition (towards the self and others) that hinder the fulfillment of basic desires/needs. Each of the ABCD elements is operationalized through a set of subelements. These subelements represent distinct psychological expressions within each element (*See Table 1*).

Table 1:

Element	Adaptive subelements	Maladaptive subelements
Affect (A) Type of emotion expressed by a writer	(1) Calm/ laid back (3) Sad, Emotional pain, grieving (5) Content, happy, joy, hopeful (7) Vigor / energetic (9) Justifiable anger/ assertive anger, justifiable outrage (11) Proud (13) Feel loved, belong	(2) Anxious/ fearful/ tense (4) Depressed, despair, hopeless (6) Mania (8) Apathic, don't care, blunted (10) Angry (aggression), disgust, contempt (12) Ashamed, guilty (14) Feel lonely
Behavior of the self with the other (B-O) The writer's main behavior(s) toward the other	(1) Relating behavior (3) Autonomous or adaptive control behavior	(2) Fight or flight behavior (4) Over controlled or controlling behavior
Behavior toward the self (B-S) The writer's main behavior(s) toward the self	(1) Self care and improvement	(2) Self harm, neglect and avoidance
Cognition of the other (C-O) The writer's main perceptions of the other	(1) Perception of the other as related (3) Perception of the other as facilitating autonomy needs	(2) Perception of the other as detached or over attached (4) Perception of the other as blocking autonomy needs
Cognition of the self (C-S) The writer's main self perceptions	(1) Self-acceptance and compassion	(2) Self criticism
Desire (D) The writer's main desire, expectation, need, intention, or fear.	(1) Relatedness (3) Autonomy and adaptive control (5) Competence, self esteem, self-care	(2) Expectation that relatedness needs will not be met (4) Expectation that autonomy needs will not be met (6) Expectation that competence needs will not be met

Task 1.1: Post level identification of Dominant ABCD subelements and Self State Composition

Given a post, teams are required to Identify which predefined ABCD subelements are meaningfully expressed in the post and how they combine into self state(s). For each of the ABCD elements (Affect, Behavior self, Behavior other, Cognition self, Cognition other, Desire) participants should identify:

- a. Which subelements are present. Note that adaptive and maladaptive subelements should be considered separately. If multiple subelements of the same valence (adaptive/maladaptive) within a given element appear to be expressed, identify the single most dominant, central, and emphasized subelement for that element and valence. If multiple subelements within the same element and the same valence (adaptive or maladaptive) appear to be expressed, identify only the single most dominant, central, and emphasized subelement.

Accordingly, within a single element (e.g. Affect), it is possible to predict both one adaptive and one maladaptive subelement, if both are clearly expressed. However, no more than one subelement per valence may be selected for a given element.

The final output must therefore consist of:

A list of subelements comprising the adaptive self state (if present), and/or a list of subelements comprising the maladaptive self state (if present). Each subelement has a predefined valence, and can therefore belong to only one self state.

Please note:

- A post may contain only an adaptive self state, only a maladaptive self state, or both. Some ABCD elements may not be present in a post.

Example of Expected Input and output for Task 1.1:

Example Input post	Example output self-state(s) composition
I'm searching for someone who could help keep me accountable with daily exercise and prevent late-night binge eating. I have a heart issue that involves low blood pressure (it doesn't increase with activity) along with a high heart rate. I need to do light activities, such as walking, every day to maintain my strength and energy. If I skip even one day, it becomes very difficult to get out of bed the following day, so staying consistent is essential for my health. I'm not overweight, but I sometimes overeat at night and would really value support in avoiding that pattern. When I consume a large amount of carbs or calories at once, it seems to worsen my symptoms. I feel more lightheaded and notice my heart rate climbing. Because of that, I really need to prevent those episodes, but at times my depression and lack of motivation take over and I end up thinking "forget it" and doing it anyway. Having someone to talk to during those moments would make a big difference. I usually begin binge eating around 10–11pm. If anyone is willing to help me stay motivated about my health, I'd truly appreciate it. We could support and encourage one another.	<u>Adaptive Self state:</u> A: (5) Content, happy, joy, hopeful B-O: (1) Relating behavior B-S: (1) Self care and improvement C-O: (1) Perception of the other as related D: (5) Competence, self esteem, self-care <u>Maladaptive Self state:</u> A: (4) Depressed, despair, hopeless B-S: (2) Self harm, neglect and avoidance D: (6) Expectation that competence needs will not be met

Task 1.2: Self State Presence Rating

Teams are required to estimate the degree to which each identified self state is present in the post. For each of the self states (adaptive and maladaptive), teams should assign a presence score on a 1-5 scale. Teams must assign a presence rating to both the adaptive and maladaptive self states identified in **Task 1.1**. If a self state is not expressed in the post, it should receive a score of 1. Presence refers to the extent to which the self state influences the person's expressed experience in the post, how strongly it was emphasized in the post. It captures how central the self state is to the overall experience described in the post. Presence ratings are independent. If both adaptive and maladaptive self states are identified in the same post, each must receive its own presence rating.

Presence Scale:

Score	Presence level	Definition
1	Not present	The self state is not expressed in the post.
2	Somewhat present	The self state is expressed, but plays a subtle, limited role in shaping the person's overall experience.
3	Moderately present	The self state is clearly expressed and moderately contributes to the person's experience.
4	Much present	The self state strongly influences and shapes the experience described in the post.
5	Highly present	The self state strongly shapes and clearly defines the overall experience described in the post.

Please note:

- Presence reflects psychological centrality and experiential influence, not mere frequency of words. Both adaptive and maladaptive self states may receive high presence scores within the same post, if both strongly shape the expressed experience.
- Presence scores should only be assigned when at least one self-state is identified in the post. If no self-states are identified, no presence scores should be given. If only one valence (adaptive or maladaptive) is represented, the other valence should receive a score of "1," indicating that it is not present in the post.
- Please consider this as a regression task, as we will be using the RMSE metric for evaluation.

Example of Expected Input and output for Task 1.2:

Example Input post	Presence scores
I'm searching for someone who could help keep me accountable with daily exercise and prevent late-night binge eating. I have a heart issue that involves low blood pressure (it doesn't increase with activity) along with a high heart rate. I need to do light activities, such as walking, every day to maintain my strength and energy. If I skip even one day, it becomes very difficult to get out of bed the following day, so staying consistent is essential for my health. I'm not overweight, but I sometimes overeat at night and would really value support in avoiding that pattern. When I consume a large amount of carbs or calories at once, it seems to worsen my symptoms. I feel more lightheaded and notice my heart rate climbing. Because of that, I really need to prevent those episodes, but at times my depression and lack of motivation take over and I end up thinking "forget it" and doing it anyway. Having someone to talk to during those moments would make a big difference. I usually begin binge eating around 10–11pm. If anyone is willing to help me stay motivated about my health, I'd truly appreciate it. We could support and encourage one another.	Adaptive Self state presence score: 4 Maladaptive Self state presence score: 2

Task 2: Identify Moments of Change (MoC)

This task focuses on detecting clinically meaningful moments of change within a chronological user timeline. Given a chronologically ordered sequence of posts from a single individual (a timeline), teams must identify two types of change:

- a. **Switch:** A switch reflects a substantial and sudden change in well-being between two consecutive posts. A switch occurs when $|\text{Wellbeing}(t) - \text{Wellbeing}(t-1)| \geq 2$. The change may reflect either improvement or deterioration. For each detected switch, teams must label post t with the tag “S” standing for switch. No additional substantive criteria were used in defining a Switch, except that when preceding wellbeing values were missing (NaN), the change was computed relative to the most recent prior non-NaN post, provided it occurred within one week.
- b. **Escalation:** An escalation refers to a gradual intensification of mood over a sequence of consecutive posts. It occurs when an individual’s mood progressively shifts from neutral or mildly valenced, toward a more extreme state (very negative or very positive) across a span of posts. Unlike a switch, which is abrupt, an escalation unfolds gradually over time. An escalation may reflect either improvement or deterioration. For each escalation event, teams must identify the full range of consecutive posts participating in the escalation, and label all posts in that range with the tag “E” standing for escalation. Escalations are not derived directly from Wellbeing score thresholds, although they may co-occur with wellbeing shifts. They were annotated according to the guidelines in (Tsakalidis et al. 2022a,b).

Please note:

- Wellbeing was operationalized using Global Assessment of Functioning (GAF) scores (American Psychiatric Association, 2000), rescaled and rounded to a 1-10 metric.
- It reflects overall psychological functioning across occupational/academic functioning, interpersonal functioning, and subjective experience of the self. Scores range from 1 (severe dysfunction or persistent risk) to 10 (excellent functioning with minimal symptoms). Each score corresponds to predefined clinical levels of symptom severity and functional capacity. Higher scores reflect stable functioning, relational reciprocity, and a coherent sense of self; lower scores reflect increasing impairment, withdrawal, or risk. The scale is anchored to fixed clinical criteria, so scores are assigned against shared clinical standards rather than relative to an individual’s usual level of functioning. If a post does not provide sufficient evidence for change, the previous score is maintained. Clear evidence is required to justify improvement or deterioration; when evidence is partial, only minimal adjustment is made.
- “S” and “E” are independent labels. It means that a post may simultaneously be part of an Escalation (“E”), and marked as a Switch (“S”).
- A post may also receive none of these labels, and will be labeled as None (“0”).

Example of Expected Input and output for Task 2:

Example Input post	Example output of change label
Post t: “Thanks so much for the advice on how to take care of my hair. I’m very pleased with the result, and it’s made me feel so much better about myself”. Post t+1: “It’s becoming more and more difficult to manage. Living with a chronic illness and trying to cope with everything that comes with it feels overwhelming lately. I’m struggling a lot. I often feel worthless, and sometimes I convince myself that being sick means I’m undeserving of love. I keep wondering what the point is if I can’t have the kind of love and life I want. I know logically that other people with chronic illnesses still deserve love and care, so I don’t understand why I have such a hard time believing that about myself. I don’t really know how to deal with these feelings anymore. My thoughts have been getting darker, and that scares me, especially because I’ve been in that place before. I know I need help, but I’m terrified of being admitted again because my past experience at the hospital was awful. The last time I felt ignored and unsafe, and it made everything worse instead of better. So right now I feel stuck, like I need support, but I don’t trust the place that is supposed to help. Maybe I just needed to get this out of me. I just feel so unworthy of love and even of life sometimes, and it’s getting harder and harder to keep coping”. Post t+2: “I plan to harm myself. I want to fall asleep and stay that way forever. I want to escape this reality. I don’t want to feel so awful anymore. I feel as if love and kindness are just not meant for me. I want to apologize to anyone whom I might have hurt. Please forgive me. I’ll try to sleep and hope it feels a little lighter later”.	Post t: 0 (Escalation label), 0 (Switch label) Post t+1: E (Escalation label), S (Switch label) Post t+2: E (Escalation label), 0 (Switch label)

Task 3: Summary of change

Task 3.1: Summarising sequences surrounding change events

The goal of Task 3.1 is to generate a structured summary describing patterns of self-state dynamics and their progression over time within a sequence of posts surrounding a change (Switch and/or Escalation). Each sequence includes posts leading up to the change, as well as posts marking the change itself. The summary must describe how psychological change processes evolve across the sequence, and how they culminate in (When it’s a Switch), or unfold through (When it’s an Escalation), the identified change event. The direction of the change (improvement/deterioration) must also be indicated. Describe the change pattern using the MIND framework (ABCD elements), and presence scores for the adaptive and maladaptive self-states. Participants will receive predefined sequences of chronologically ordered posts corresponding to a window surrounding a change event (Switch or Escalation), but the exact post at which the change event occurs will not be explicitly marked.

Please note:

- Overlap between change events may occur and may be used as part of the explanation of the mental dynamic of change.
- The direction of the change (improvement/deterioration) must be indicated.

- It should be explicitly stated what dynamics characterized the pre-change phase, and how these dynamics culminated in the change event (in the case of a Switch) or unfolded through the change process (in the case of an Escalation).

For the creation of the summary, you may use the posts, change labels **from Task 2 (Switches, Escalations)**, your self-state presence scores from **Task 1.2**, and the self-state subelement compositions from **Task 1.1**. The summary should include references, only when they are evident in the data, to the following aspects:

- 1. Central recurring theme across the posts:** Describe the central dynamic psychological theme and change trajectory characterizing the change process across the sequence, articulated in terms of ABCD subelements: Affect; Behavior toward self and Behavior toward others; Cognition toward self and Cognition toward others; and Desire, grounded in concrete content from the posts. Explain how this theme evolves across the sequence. The description of the theme should reflect the relational dynamics between these ABCD subelements within and between self-states, as defined in the sections below. The theme should be described across the stages of the change process within the sequence, making clear how the theme appears before the change and how it develops as the change unfolds.
- 2. Dynamics within the Adaptive and Maladaptive self-states:** Describe how present each self-state is and how its relative presence changes throughout the sequence as part of the change process. Presence refers to how strongly each self-state is expressed or dominant at different points in the sequence, whereas dynamics refer to the interactions between the ABCD subelements within that self-state. Where present, describe the adaptive and/or the maladaptive self-states in terms of Affect, Behavior, Cognition and Desire, expressing these ABCD subelements through explicit relational dynamics between them within the same self-state. If a self-state is described, relational dynamics between its ABCD subelements **MUST** also be described. Dynamics within a self-state are relational patterns between two or more subelements within the same self-state. These dynamics may be directional or reciprocal, such as co-activation, mutual reinforcement, exacerbation of one element by another, amplification of one element by another, or other structured interactions. This list is not exhaustive; other forms of dynamics may also be identified where conceptually appropriate. These relational dynamics between subelements within a self-state should be described as they unfold across the sequence, noting how they change over time.
- 3. Relationship between the adaptive and maladaptive self states:** Describe how the adaptive and maladaptive self-states relate to one another and how that changes throughout the sequence. Describe how the relative presence and dominance of the adaptive and maladaptive self-states shifts across the sequence. This may include: one self-state dominating the other, suppressing or silencing the other, or both self-states coexisting through reflective dialogue. Use presence scores to support comparison over the sequence, but do not print numeric scores in the output. Additionally, examine whether dynamics occur between ABCD subelements across opposite self-states (suppression/attenuation, reflective dialogue, dominance competition, or other

structured interactions). If such cross-self-state dynamics are present in the sequence, they MUST be described.

Each reference to an ABCD element should include its abbreviation in parentheses. Use the following mapping: (A) for Affect; (B-S) for Behavior-self; (B-O) for Behavior-other; (C-S) for Cognition-self; (C-O) for Cognition-other; (D) for Desire.

Example for the Sequence Summary Task 3.1

Timeline **d0fb4b962e** Posts **6, 7, 9, 10** (*8 is excluded for having no meaningful content*).

- The original posts have been slightly modified to protect user privacy and maintain confidentiality.

Post index 6

- MOC label: -
- Wellbeing score = 7
- Maladaptive presence: (1), Adaptive presence: (3)
- Maladaptive self-state composition: -
- Adaptive self-state composition: B-O - (1) Relating behavior, D - (1) Relatedness
- Post: "Does anyone here have a job? I know this isn't really related to the sub, but I was curious whether anyone here is employed. If so, what kind of work do you do?"

Post index 7

- MOC label: -
- Wellbeing score = 7
- Maladaptive presence: 3, Adaptive presence: 2
- Maladaptive self-state composition: A - (4) Depressed, despair, hopeless, B-S - (2) Self harm, neglect and avoidance, C-S - (2) Self criticism, D - (6) Expectation that competence needs will not be met
- Adaptive self-state composition: A - (11) Proud, B-S - (1) Self care and improvement
- Post: After a week, I'm back to square one. I was really proud that I managed to go seven days without drinking, but I ended up relapsing. And it was to Vodka. It makes me feel terrible, thinking that I might never be able to stop drinking that shit—or alcohol in general.

Post index 9

- MOC label: Escalation
- Wellbeing score = 6
- Maladaptive presence: 4, Adaptive presence: 2
- Maladaptive self-state composition: A - (4) Depressed, despair, hopeless, B-S - (2) Self harm, neglect and avoidance, B-O - (2) Fight or flight behavior, C-S - (2) Self criticism, C-O - (2) Perception of the other as detached or over attached, D - (2) Expectation that relatedness needs will not be met
- Adaptive self-state composition : B-O - (1) Relating behavior, D - (5) Competence, self esteem, self-care
- Post : When relatives or friends bring it up, I wish I could be honest with them. Sometimes we're just having a regular conversation and out of nowhere they ask, "When are you going to get a girlfriend?" I usually make excuses because I don't want to admit the real reasons — including that I'm insecure about my penis size and that I don't have a girlfriend for several reasons. One of those reasons is that I'm pretty socially withdrawn. I spend most of my time in my room and rarely go out, aside from occasionally going to the movies. When I try to talk to women, I get anxious and struggle to keep the conversation going. I also feel like my vocabulary is limited; at times I'm unsure about the meaning of certain words or how to use them properly in a sentence. I'm also overweight for my height (5'6"). I've attempted to diet, but I tend to fall back into eating junk food. I deal with depression much of the time and often find myself stuck in negative thinking. I've been considering seeing a psychologist to help with depression and some of these other difficulties. Has anyone here spoken with a psychologist? If so, what was your experience like, and did it help?

Post index 10

- MOC label: Switch, Escalation
- Wellbeing score = 4
- Maladaptive presence: 5, Adaptive presence: 2
- Maladaptive self-state composition: A - (4) Depressed, despair, hopeless, B-O - (2) Fight or flight behavior, C-S - (2) Self criticism, C-O - (2) Perception of the other as detached or over attached, D - (6) Expectation that competence needs will not be met
- Adaptive self-state composition : D - (5) Competence, self esteem, self-care

- **Post:** All of this feels like it's going to affect me in my future responsibilities. What I mean is that I tend to be very slow to process things and I get distracted easily. For instance, when I'm sitting in class and the professor is explaining something, I often don't absorb what's being said. Instead, my mind drifts off to thoughts about a movie, a game, or something I saw earlier that day. This has been an issue for me since school, and it's still happening now that I'm in university. I also feel like my vocabulary is limited, and sometimes I struggle to form a sentence because I can't find the right word to finish it. Staying focused on a task is difficult, and that's really frustrating. On top of that, I'm frequently stuck in negative thoughts — sometimes to the extent that I think about killing myself because I see myself as stupid and incapable of achieving anything in life. My mother spends a lot of money on me, and I wish she wouldn't, because I feel like I'm not going anywhere. I would give anything to function like a normal person, but as things are now, I sometimes think it would be better if I weren't here causing stress for everyone.

Sequence Summary: The central theme emerging through the deterioration is the individual's suffering around a sense of being irregular and incompetent (C-S). A process of gradual deterioration can be observed, beginning with self criticism related to being different and addicted to alcohol (C-S), fueling feelings of shame (A), while experiencing hopelessness regarding his ability to change (D). This is accompanied by avoidant behavior (B-O), such as social withdrawal and remaining in his room, which further reinforces the belief of being defective (C-S), creating a circular dynamic between cognition (C-S), affect (A), and behavior (B-S). At this stage, the maladaptive self-state is moderately present and progressively increasing in intensity, while a weaker adaptive self-state remains present at a lower level. The adaptive self-state is expressed through a longing for acceptance and for receiving professional help (D), and the intent to speak honestly with others (B-O), indicating some retained orientation toward connection. Over time, an escalation towards deterioration begins, as the maladaptive self-state becomes highly present and increasingly dominant. Self criticism (C-S) intensifies, hopelessness (D) deepens, and depressive affect (A) becomes more pervasive. The adaptive self-state, while still intermittently present through the wish for help (D), becomes progressively suppressed by the escalating hopeless cognition (C-S), which attenuates the belief that change is possible (D). The deterioration culminates in a switch, as self criticism (C-S) reaches extreme intensity, hopeless expectation becomes rigid and global, and is expressed by emerging suicidal ideation (D). At this point, the maladaptive self-state is highly central and dominant, while the adaptive self-state becomes minimally present.

Task 3.2: Identifying Recurrent Dynamic Signatures of Change Across Timelines

Building on the framework used in Task 3.1, your goal is to identify and summarize recurrent dynamic patterns of deterioration (a switch towards lower well-being, or an escalation of deterioration) or improvement (a switch towards higher well-being, or an escalation of improvement) that recur across multiple sequences. Using the MIND (ABCD) framework and self-state structure, analyse how self-states and their elements interact and evolve in sequences surrounding identified change events. Focus on patterns that recur across multiple individuals.

Across timelines, identify the most frequent patterns in:

- Central Theme:** Recurrent themes of deterioration or improvement articulated in ABCD elements
- Dynamics within self states:** Recurrent ABCD configurations (separately for the maladaptive and adaptive self states), dynamics among subelements within the same self-state, changes in presence of a self state across the sequence leading to and through the change event.
- Dynamics between self-states:** Patterns in the balance between self-states in terms of presence over time (patterns of dominance versus coexistence), is there a dialogue/reflection between the self states or silencing dominance and how does this change over time, dynamics between subelements from different self-states over time.

Based on these patterns, extract:

1. 3 Signatures of Deterioration
2. 3 Signatures of Improvement

Each signature should describe a recurrent dynamic pattern (ABCD + self-state relations) observed across individuals that leads to and culminates as the change occurs. Base all points on observable dynamic patterns in the timelines.

Examples of Recurrent Dynamic Signatures of change:

Example for signatures of deterioration:

A recurrent deterioration pattern involved expectations of rejection (D) that drove avoidant behavior (B-O) and escalating self-criticism (C-S), reinforcing and amplifying loneliness and hopeless affect (A). Adaptive voices expressing needs for connection and affirmation (D) were progressively overshadowed by a dominant self-critical perception (C-S). Presence scores indicated increasing dominance of the maladaptive self-state and a gradual reduction in the regulatory presence of the adaptive self-state, until eventually the maladaptive self-state suppresses the adaptive self-state.

Example for signatures of improvement:

A recurrent improvement pattern included the articulation of needs for support and closeness (D) activated approach-oriented behavior (B-O), which enabled hope and relief (A). Self-critical cognitions (C-S) became objects of reflection and were increasingly regulated by more compassionate cognitive perception towards the self (C-S). Within the adaptive self-state, desires for connection (D), approach behaviors (B-O) and hopeful affect (A) co-activated and mutually reinforced one another, strengthening its regulatory impact. Presence scores indicated a gradual increase in the adaptive self-state and a corresponding reduction in the dominance of the maladaptive self-state, and the dynamic shifted from silencing dominance of the maladaptive self-state into a reflective dialogue between the two.

Data Description:

The dataset consists of 40 timelines in total, divided into a training set of 30 timelines and a test set of 10 timelines. The training timelines are intended to support the development and calibration of the system submissions, while the test timelines are reserved for evaluating the consistency and generalizability of the participating teams submissions during the test phase.

Training data:

Participants will receive a structured training dataset containing:

- Posted text - for each entry in a person's timeline.
- Metadata (date, post ID, timeline ID, post index within the timeline).
- Switch labels - indicating moments of significant change in wellbeing.
- Escalation labels - indicating a gradual change in the person's mood.
- Wellbeing scores for each post.
- Sequence-level summaries leading to and including Switches. *(Task 3 release)*
- Sequence-level summaries leading to and including Escalations. *(Task 3 release)*
- Adaptive and Maladaptive self-state presence scores (1-5) per post.
- Adaptive and Maladaptive Affect-Behaviour-Cognition-Desire (ABCD) categories per post.
- Adaptive and Maladaptive ABCD subelement categories with corresponding textual evidence spans per post.

Note: The sequence-level summaries for **Switches** and **Escalations** will be provided **during the Task 3 release** and are **not included in the Task 1 and 2 materials**.

Test data:

Participants will receive:

- Post text - for each entry in the timeline.
- Metadata (date, Post ID, Timeline ID, post index within the timeline).

Evaluation:

Task 1.1: ABCD Element & Subelement Classification

Metrics:

- Element presence is evaluated as 12 binary classifications (6 elements - {A, B-O, B-S, C-O, C-S, D} × 2 valences {adaptive-state, maladaptive-state}) using Precision, Recall, and F1.
- Subelement classification is evaluated as multi-class F1 per element over the valid subelement categories.
- Metrics are aggregated per-valence (adaptive/maladaptive) and overall over all subelements.
- Only posts with annotated evidence in the gold data are evaluated.

Ranking aggregation:

- Compute F1 per element (12 total: 6 adaptive + 6 maladaptive)
- Macro average across 6 elements within each valence → Adaptive Macro F1, Maladaptive Macro F1
- Average of Adaptive and Maladaptive Macro F1

Ranking: mean(Adaptive Macro F1, Maladaptive Macro F1)

Task 1.2: Presence Rating

Metrics:

- Adaptive and maladaptive Presence ratings (1–5 scale) are evaluated using MAE, RMSE, Quadratic Weighted Kappa (QWK), and Spearman correlation.
- Reported separately for adaptive, maladaptive, and combined.

Ranking: mean(Adaptive RMSE, Maladaptive RMSE) - lower is better.

Task 2: Moments of Change

Metrics:

- Switch and Escalation are evaluated as independent binary classifications.
- Post-level: Precision, Recall, and F1 per label, pooled across all posts.
- Timeline-level: Precision, Recall, and F1 per label, macro-averaged across timelines.
- All posts are evaluated (including those without annotated evidence).

Ranking aggregation:

1. Macro F1 = mean of Switch F1 and Escalation F1 (computed separately at post-level and timeline-level)

Ranking: mean(Post-level Macro F1, Timeline-level Macro F1)

Task 3:

- The evaluation will be released ahead of Task 3 phase.

Important: A validation script (`validate_submission.py`) is provided to check submission files before uploading. It verifies field formats, value ranges, and duplicate entries, and warns if post text is detected in submissions — all post text fields must be removed before submitting for privacy reasons. Optionally, pass `--test-dir` to check that predictions cover all test posts with no extra entries.

System Submission (Codabench competitions):

Submission Responsibility: Prior to making any submissions, each participating team must provide the organizers with the Codabench user ID of a designated team member for each Codabench page associated with the tasks. This designated user will act as the team's official representative on the platform and will be responsible for making submissions on behalf of the team.

Participants will submit their system predictions to the CLPsych 2026 Shared Task Codabench competitions for automated scoring. Each team is permitted up to 3 submissions per Task, unless stated otherwise by the organizers:

- **Task 1:** <https://www.codabench.org/competitions/14057/> (*Public by March 24th AOE*).
- **Task 2:** <https://www.codabench.org/competitions/14703/> (*Public by March 24th AOE*).
- **Task 3:** <https://www.codabench.org/competitions/14669/> (*Public by April 13th AOE*).

They will also have the option to publish their scores to the competition's leaderboard. For submission guidelines and format of prediction files, please see the Codabench "Evaluation" page.

Please Note: The Codabench leaderboard will only be used for participants to publish their scores. Each Subtask (Task 1.1 and 1.2) will have its own scoring criteria. Codabench does not support rankings based on multiple scores or multiple leaderboards. As such, the ranking shown on the Codabench leaderboard is NOT representative of team rankings.

Submission Format:

Participants submit **separate JSON files** for Task 1 and Task 2. Each file is a JSON array of per-post prediction objects. Participants may submit predictions for one or both tasks. If a prediction file for a task is not provided, that task will be skipped and only the other task will be scored.

Important: Do NOT include post text (e.g., "post", "text", "body") in your submission files. Remove all post text fields before uploading. The validation script will warn you if text fields are detected.

Participants must include their Task 1 predictions in a file called `task1_pred.json`. They must include their Task 2 predictions in a file called `task2_pred.json`. To submit to the Codabench competition for scoring, they must zip their prediction files into a single compressed folder. This zip folder must be uploaded to the Codabench page for that corresponding Task.

Task 1 Example (Submit to Task 1 Codabench page):

predictions.zip
|- task1_pred.json

Task 2 Example (Submit to Task 2 Codabench page):

predictions.zip
|- task2_pred.json

Task 1 Submission (task1_pred.json):

A JSON array. Each entry is one post with predicted self-states. Posts from all timelines are expected in a single list without partitioning per timeline:

```
[
{
  "timeline_id": "91b6a42835",
  "post_id": "28641e5b6d",
  "adaptive-state": {
    "Presence": 5,
    "B-S": { "subelement": 1 },
    "B-O": { "subelement": 1 },
    "C-S": { "subelement": 1 },
    "D": { "subelement": 3 }
  },
  "maladaptive-state": {
    "Presence": 2,
    "C-S": { "subelement": 2 }
  }
},
{
  "timeline_id": "306d938d4b",
  "post_id": "308b0c2c6c",
  "adaptive-state": {
    "Presence": 2,
    "B-S": { "subelement": 1 },
    "B-O": { "subelement": 1 }
  },
  "maladaptive-state": {
    "Presence": 2,
    "A": { "subelement": 2 }
  }
}
]
```

Field	Type	Required	Description
timeline_id	string	Yes	Must match a timeline in the test data
post_id	string	Yes	Must match a post in the test data
adaptive-state	object	No	Omit entirely if no adaptive state predicted
maladaptive-state	object	No	Omit entirely if no maladaptive state predicted
{state}.Presence	integer (1-5)	Yes, if state is present	Psychological centrality rating

{state}.{element}	object	No. Omitted elements will be scored as not present	Include only elements predicted as present
{state}.{element}.subelement	integer	Yes, if element is present	Must be a valid index for this element x valence (see Table 1. above)

- **Elements:** A, B-O, B-S, C-O, C-S, D
- Exactly one subelement per element per valence.
- Only include entries for posts that have annotated evidence in the gold data. Posts without gold evidence are ignored during evaluation

Task 2 Submission (task2_pred.json)

A JSON array. Each entry is one post with Switch and Escalation labels. Posts from all timelines are expected in a single list without partitioning per timeline:

```
[
  {
    "timeline_id": "3db8573df5",
    "post_id": "e383f54895",
    "Switch": "0",
    "Escalation": "0"
  },
  {
    "timeline_id": "3db8573df5",
    "post_id": "77cbbd5cc2",
    "Switch": "S",
    "Escalation": "E"
  }
]
```

Field	Type	Required	Description
timeline_id	string	Yes	Must match a timeline in the test data
post_id	string	Yes	Must match a post in the test data
Switch	string	Yes	"S" for switch, "0" for no switch
Escalation	string	Yes	"E" for escalation, "0" for no escalation

- Must include an entry for every post in the test data.
- Switch and Escalation are independent — a post can be labeled as both "S" and "E".

Task 3 Submission (task3_pred.json):

The Task 3 submission format will be made available ahead of the Task 3 evaluation period (April 13).

Paper Submission:

Please ensure that your paper complies with the following requirements before submission. Although teams are encouraged to tackle and submit solutions for all tasks in order to obtain a clearer overview of this year's challenge, participation in any subset of subtasks is allowed. Teams will be invited to submit system description papers detailing their approaches and results; however, **paper submission is optional**

1. Paper Format

- The paper must follow the official formatting guidelines (see [here](#)).
- The main paper is limited to 4 pages.
- The Appendix does not count toward the 4-page limit.

2. Required Sections

Your paper must include the following sections:

- **Ethics Section:** Include a discussion of ethical considerations relevant to the dataset, task, and methodology.
- **Limitations Section:** Clearly describe the limitations of your approach, experiments, or findings.

3. Anonymity Requirements

To preserve anonymity during the review process:

- Mentioning the team name is allowed.
- Do not include the names of individual team members anywhere in the paper.

4. Compliance with the Data Access Form

All submissions must comply with the [Data Access Form](#) requirements, including:

- **Use of Models**
 - Participants must use only open-source models for all work related to the CLPsych 2026 shared task. Proprietary or closed-source models are not permitted at any stage of experimentation, analysis, or submission preparation.
- **Data Handling and Privacy**
 - Participants must not submit, upload, or share any part of the provided dataset with systems or platforms that may store the data or use it for training purposes. This restriction includes, but is not limited to, proprietary APIs and services such as ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or similar tools.
- **Compliance Responsibility**
 - Participants are responsible for ensuring that all tools, workflows, and collaborators comply with these requirements throughout the duration of the shared task.

5. Privacy Protection in Examples

If you include examples from the dataset:

- Any examples appearing in figures, the main text, prompts, or the appendix must be paraphrased.
- You must explicitly state in writing that the examples have been paraphrased for privacy.
- This statement can be included, for example, in the figure caption or accompanying text.

6. Required Citations

The CLPsych 2026 shared task overview paper.
(Reference will be provided to participants ahead of the paper writing phase)

```
@inproceedings{tseriotou-et-al-2025-overview,
  title = "Overview of the {CLP}sych 2025 Shared Task: Capturing Mental Health Dynamics from Social Media Timelines",
  author = "Tseriotou, Talia and
    Chim, Jenny and
    Klein, Ayal and
    Shamir, Aya and
    Dvir, Guy and
    Ali, Iqra and
    Kennedy, Cian and
    Singh Kohli, Guneet and
    Hills, Anthony and
    Zirikly, Ayah and
    Atzil-Slonim, Dana and
    Liakata, Maria",
  editor = "Zirikly, Ayah and
    Yates, Andrew and
    Desmet, Bart and
    Ireland, Molly and
    Bedrick, Steven and
    MacAvaney, Sean and
    Bar, Kfir and
    Ophir, Yaakov",
  booktitle = "Proceedings of the 10th Workshop on Computational Linguistics and Clinical Psychology (CLPsych 2025)",
  month = may,
  year = "2025",
  address = "Albuquerque, New Mexico",
  publisher = "Association for Computational Linguistics",
  url = "https://aclanthology.org/2025.clpsych-1.16/",
  doi = "10.18653/v1/2025.clpsych-1.16",
  pages = "193--217",
  ISBN = "979-8-89176-226-8",
  abstract = "We provide an overview of the CLPsych 2025 Shared Task, which focuses on capturing mental health dynamics from social media timelines. Building on CLPsych 2022's longitudinal modeling approach, this work combines monitoring mental states with evidence and summary generation through four subtasks: (A.1) Evidence Extraction, highlighting text spans reflecting adaptive or maladaptive self-states; (A.2) Well-Being Score Prediction, assigning posts a 1 to 10 score based on social, occupational, and psychological functioning; (B) Post-level Summarization of the interplay between adaptive and maladaptive states within individual posts; and (C) Timeline-level Summarization capturing temporal dynamics of self-states over posts in a timeline. We describe key findings and future directions."
}
```

```
@misc{atzil_slonim_2025_mind,
  author = {Atzil-Slonim, Dana},
  title = {Multimodal Intrapersonal and Interpersonal Dynamics (MIND): A Transtheoretical Coding Manual},
  year = {2025},
  month = oct,
  publisher = {Open Science Framework},
  doi = {10.17605/OSF.IO/SJE8C},
  url = {https://osf.io/sje8c}
}
```

```
@inproceedings{tsakalidis-et-al-2022-overview,
  title = "Overview of the {CLP}sych 2022 Shared Task: Capturing Moments of Change in Longitudinal User Posts",
  author = "Tsakalidis, Adam and
    Chim, Jenny and
    Bilal, Iman Munire and
    Zirikly, Ayah and
    Atzil-Slonim, Dana and
    Nanni, Federico and
```

```

Resnik, Philip and
Gaur, Manas and
Roy, Kaushik and
Inkster, Becky and
Leintz, Jeff and
Liakata, Maria",
editor = "Zirikly, Ayah and
Atzil-Slonim, Dana and
Liakata, Maria and
Bedrick, Steven and
Desmet, Bart and
Ireland, Molly and
Lee, Andrew and
MacAvaney, Sean and
Purver, Matthew and
Resnik, Rebecca and
Yates, Andrew",
booktitle = "Proceedings of the Eighth Workshop on Computational Linguistics and Clinical
Psychology",
month = jul,
year = "2022",
address = "Seattle, USA",
publisher = "Association for Computational Linguistics",
url = "https://aclanthology.org/2022.clpsych-1.16/",
doi = "10.18653/v1/2022.clpsych-1.16",
pages = "184--198",
abstract = "We provide an overview of the CLPsych 2022 Shared Task, which focusses on the
automatic identification of 'Moments of Change' in longitudinal posts by individuals on social media
and its connection with information regarding mental health . This year's task introduced the notion
of longitudinal modelling of the text generated by an individual online over time, along with
appropriate temporally sensitive evaluation metrics. The Shared Task consisted of two subtasks: (a)
the main task of capturing changes in an individual's mood (drastic changes-'Switches'- and
gradual changes-'Escalations'- on the basis of textual content shared online; and subsequently (b)
the sub-task of identifying the suicide risk level of an individual {--} a continuation of the CLPsych 2019
Shared Task{--} where participants were encouraged to explore how the identification of changes in
mood in task (a) can help with assessing suicidality risk in task (b).
}

```

```

@incollection{atzil_slonim_2026,
  author = {Atzil-Slonim, Dana},
  title = {Leveraging Theoretical and Technological Innovations to Study the Mechanisms That
Underlie Therapeutic Change in Psychotherapy},
  booktitle = {Practice-Based Evidence in the Psychological Therapies: Toward Policy Implications for
Research, Training, and Clinical Guidelines},
  editor = {Castonguay, Louis G. and Atzil-Slonim, Dana and Barkham, Michael and Lutz, Wolfgang},
  publisher = {Oxford University Press},
  address = {New York},
  year = {2026},
  url =
{https://global.oup.com/academic/product/practice-based-evidence-in-the-psychological-therapies-9
780197748305AP}
}

```

7. **Reported Results**

- The results reported in the paper must match the official results listed in the shared Condabench.
- If you conduct additional evaluations, these may also be included in your paper.
- However, you must include the results corresponding to your official submission in the Condabench and clearly state that these are the submitted results.

8. **Clarity of the Paper**

- Your paper should clearly describe: The task, the methodology, the experimental setup, the evaluation procedure

- The description should be detailed enough that readers can fully understand your approach and results without ambiguity.

9. **English Language**

- Ensure that the paper is written in clear and correct English.

10. **Camera-Ready Revisions**

- After reviews are received, teams will be given one additional page in the camera-ready version to address reviewer comments. Participants are encouraged to consider possible improvements such as: Clarifying explanations, Expanding the discussion of results, Adding qualitative analysis where relevant.

Submissions and Paper Reviews:

- All submissions will go through the **Softconf/START Conference Manager** at <https://softconf.com/acl2026/CLPsych>. Regardless of participants' decision to submit a paper, **by April 21st** they must submit a **short one-paragraph summary (about 75 words)** of their best system along with the codabench submission ID for each subtask they participated in to igra.ali@qmul.ac.uk to be included in the shared task overview paper.
- Additionally, **each team is required to complete one official review during the reviewing process**, review guidelines will be shared during the review phase.

Organizers:

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Contact Details:

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Or the following organizers directly:

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[Maria Liakata](#) (Queen Mary University of London & The Alan Turing Institute)

References:

[1] Tsakalidis, A., Chim, J., Bilal, I.M., Zirikly, A., Atzil-Slonim, D., Nanni, F., Resnik, P., Gaur, M., Roy, K., Inkster, B. and Leintz, J., 2022, July. Overview of the CLPsych 2022 shared task: Capturing moments of change in longitudinal user posts. In Proceedings of the Eighth Workshop on Computational Linguistics and Clinical Psychology (pp. 184-198).

[2] Tsakalidis, A., Nanni, F., Hills, A., Chim, J., Song, J. and Liakata, M., 2022, May. Identifying moments of change from longitudinal user text. In Proceedings of the 60th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (Volume 1: Long Papers) (pp. 4647-4660).

[3] Dana Atzil-Slonim. 2025. Multimodal Intrapersonal and Interpersonal Dynamics (MIND): A Transtheoretical Coding Manual. <https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/SJE8C>